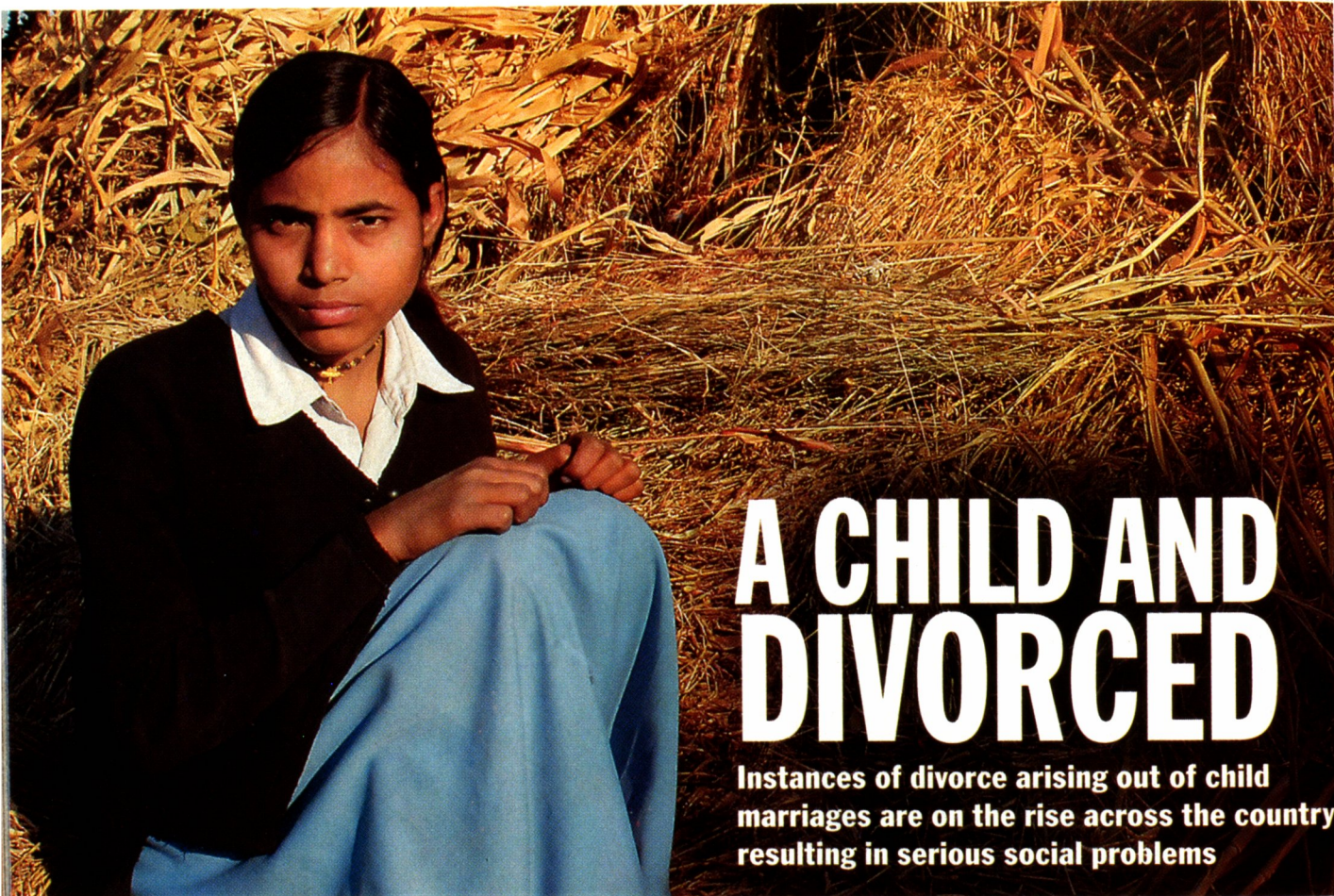




A CHILD AND DIVORCED

Instances of divorce arising out of child marriages are on the rise across the country resulting in serious social problems

■ By Rohit Parihar

Here's a shocking statistic. There are over 1.7 lakh divorces that take place among couples who are yet to reach the official marriageable age in the country. Around 1.6 crore child marriages continue to take place in parts of India, ignoring the law and bowing to ancient customs that belong to the Dark Ages. By far the largest numbers are from a caste-ridden Rajasthan where children as young as four, five or even less are married off or traded like so many cattle. According to the 2001 census, of the 1.6 crore children in India who got married before they reach official marriageable age, 18.3 lakh came from Rajasthan alone. Which also explains why of the estimated 1.7 lakh divorces that take place before the children reach marriageable age, the largest number, around 6,200, are from Rajasthan.

A survey undertaken for INDIA TODAY by NGO Prayas in Shahpura block of the state's Bhilwara district showed 181

▲ **MEERA MALI, 13, VILLAGE DABLA KACHRA**
Meera and her sister got married under the *atta-satta* custom to two brothers. The failure of her sister's marriage meant hers had to end too.

"I often come across my husband on my way but we do not talk."

cases of broken child marriages in just one village Dabla Kachra. Another 200 cases were found at random in six other villages in the same block. Meera Mali, age 13, studying in Class V in the village Dabla Kachra is one of the 3.7 lakh children in her state and 20 lakh across the country who got married before the age of 14—too young to even remember the ceremony, if there was one. And like 50,000 others in the country and 1,200 in the state under the age of 15, she got separated from her so-called husband as swiftly as she had entered into wedlock with him.

Meera's life was inextricably linked with that of her elder sister Leela. When Leela got married to Narain Lal Mali, Meera was given in marriage to

his younger brother Bansi Lal Mali. But a few years later, when Leela refused to go back to her in-laws and settled down with another man Laduji, it was Meera who had to bear the brunt of her sister's actions. Laduji paid Rs 70,000 as compensation to Narain and "bought" over Leela. But in the process Meera became a "left-over" girl even before she knew what marriage was as her in-laws refused to accept her in retaliation for her sister's actions. Aptly enough, this traditional system is called *atta-satta*, meaning exchange. As a result if one marriage breaks, the other alliance automatically stands cancelled.

Interestingly, while there has not been much change in the age when children are married, the age of *gauna*—the ritual marking the start of the bride's stay with her husband—has gone up considerably in most communities. While it has had a positive effect on the health of girls as it advances the age at which they enter motherhood, it has also had a negative fallout in that most breakups take place at the time